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Coding and Ethics

Ethics is often the most grey and complicated area of any field; Computer Science and coding are no exception. When considering the impact that one's projects will have on the field of Computer Science and technology as well as on the public and population as a whole, we would be remiss to not consider the ethics behind and surrounding the project. Ethics are relatively subjective but that does not mean that there should not be some sort of agreed upon base standard. Christians in particular are held by their beliefs to a higher code of conduct that other programmers may feel called to uphold. After all, ethics standards should be designed to protect the user and programmer while still promoting the furtherance of the field.

Copyright is all around us and plays a larger role in ethics than many people realize. From the programs that we use to the music we listen to and books we read; copyright is a part of our everyday life. Despite its prevalence, many people do not really understand what copyright is. In the field of Computer Science, it is designed to show and protect the ownership of a product or program. Copyright is also designed to protect and promote creativity of products and programs by other users. As the Media Education Lab video "Copyright? What's Copyright?" says, copyright is designed to "promote creativity and balancing rights of users and owners of intellectual property." When it comes to programming copyright is very important and a part of every project for this very reason. Many if not all programs have some sort of reliance on other programs or will be used in other programs by other users. Whether it is the creator making use of

the work of others or other programmers using the project in their own creative endeavors, there is a duty to uphold a certain standard of conduct. It is only right to credit the creator and to give them the respect of using their programs in the ways that they intended and allowed.

After reading Open Source Guides article, “The Legal Side of Open Source,” and comparing their different licenses, I believe the one that is fair and best fits my programs is a MIT license. As of right now I am mostly working on small simple projects. However, this does not mean that I do not want others to be able to edit or use my projects. In fact, I want it to happen, as it shows my growth and capability as a programmer. I am not a large corporation, I want others to build off of my work “but because the legal default is still exclusive copyright, ...[I] need a license that explicitly states these permissions” (Open Source Guides, The Legal Side of Open Source). An MIT license allows me to license my projects and programs while still allowing for the easy modification and use of them. If in the future I were to take on more serious projects and begin programming for large corporations, I may take on and use a more extensive and detailed license. As my programs get more intricate, I would need a license that would reflect and protect that, but for now an MIT license would easily cover all my needs.

All programmers have obligations when reusing code from the internet and the obligations are greater for programmers that are also Christians who answer not just to ethical codes but to God. When reusing code from the internet the first things that we need to keep in mind are the ethical principles that many programmers have agreed upon. These can be seen in the ACM and IEEE codes of conduct and ethics. The ACM Code of Ethics principles state that all programming should value human well-being and better society in some way, because of this they should also minimize any harmful effects, that they should not be deceitful but instead trustworthy, since it is for the good of society they should not discriminate, they should maintain any understandings of

confidentiality of collected information, respect the work of others by crediting them when used, and respecting the privacy of their users (ACM, ACM Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct). The IEEE code of ethics holds that programmers should be responsible and ethical, maintaining integrity in their work, to not harm, harass, or discriminate others by treating them fairly and with respect, and to encourage other programmers to maintain these same standards (IEEE Policies, pg 36). Both have similarities; they focus on the fair treatment of all users and the need to minimize the harm that may be intentionally or unintentionally inflicted on their users. However, the ACM code of conduct and ethics goes more in depth, citing extra ethical obligations for professionals in management positions.

When reusing code from the internet it is very important for programmers to follow these ethical guidelines. For example, a user who thoughtlessly downloads code from an online website and does not care about their ethical responsibilities may use it to create a program that performs malicious actions on a user's computer. The programmer may think that it is harmless, only a joke to bother a user, however their actions do not follow the ethical guidelines of minimizing harm and not harassing users. Even if meant as a joke, programs should not be made to cause unnecessary harm as the program could cause more harm than the programmer ever realized or intended. The effects of malicious jokes or programs can spread quickly and lead to mental and physical harm of users. To minimize these events, pay close attention to the code of others, do not knowingly spread code that is designed to harm others because then you are not trying to minimize harm towards others. They should also run their code by other trustworthy coders to make sure that they are following ethical guidelines. Doing so allows them to help catch and change any problems you might have as they should also be working to better and spread the good influence that programming can have. We are all bound like it or not by an ethical code of conduct and must

be willing to follow it ourselves and pressure those around us to for the preservation and betterment of our society.

Works Cited

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